Visual Studio LIVE!
EXPERT SOLUTIONS FOR ENTERPRISE DEVELOPERS | Las Vegas

Navigating Your Career as a Software Engineer

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Level: Introduction/Intermediate

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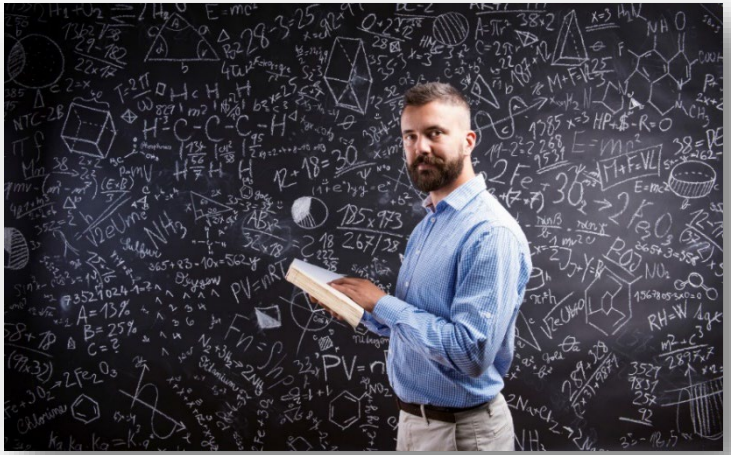
Primer / Getting Started

Insights and Perspective



20+ Years as an Engineer

The Career: Software Engineering

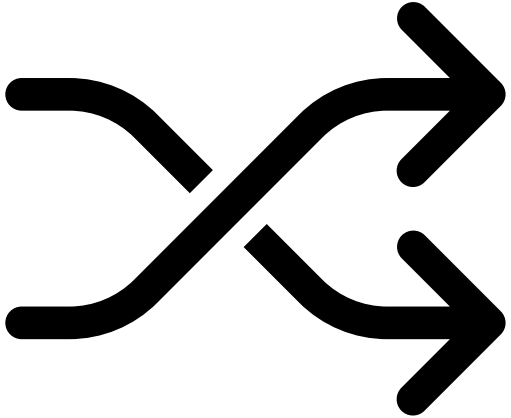
- Why software engineering?
  - Innovative / Creative
  - Challenging
  - Continuous learning
  - Demand / Job Security
  - Compensation
  - Diverse tech landscape
  - Multiple career paths
  - Work remotely
- Fast-growing and ever evolving field
- Multiple Career Paths & Opportunities

Types of Jobs, Titles and Roles

- Job Types
  - Fulltime Engineer
    - Corporate (Public or Private)
    - Government
    - Startup
  - Consultant
  - Contractor
  - Entrepreneur / Owner
  - Manager / Leader
  - Professor / Teacher
- Titles
  - Programmer (…Senior)
  - Software Engineer 1..n
  - Software Developer
  - Architect (many flavors)
  - Tech Lead
  - Principal
  - Distinguished Engineer
  - Grand Poohbah

- Roles
  - Team Contributor
    - Programmer
    - Software Engineer
  - Team Leader
    - Tech Lead
    - Dev Lead
    - Architect
    - Dev Manager

Titles are… Inconsistent



- There is no industry standard on titles
  - Can vary greatly between companies
- Don’t get caught up on the title
  - Roles and Responsibilities mean more
- Understand career progression paths
  - Relative to current employer

Career Transitions: Starting Strong

- Build experience early and often
- Don't compromise on your career objectives
- Build *and maintain* your online profile
- Get formal, take the interviewing process seriously
- Gravitate toward the best at your job
- Be intentional about tech choices and company fit
- Approach each new challenge with a fresh mindset
- Avoid common missteps, even in unfamiliar territory
  - Be humble, good things will come

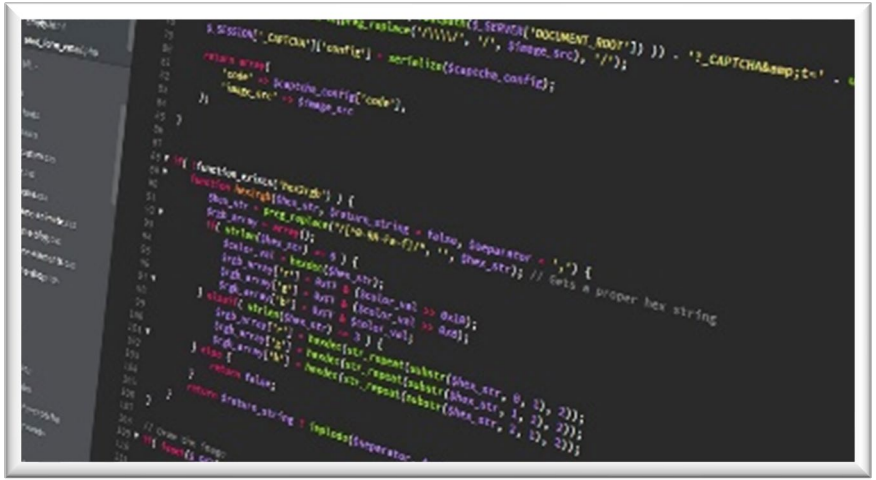
Career Drift: Indicators

- Software Engineering *potential* cautionary points
  - Stress / Deadlines
  - Global time availability
  - Longer hours
  - Company consolidated/merged/sold
  - Desk-bound lifestyle
  - Isolation
  - Rapid technology changes
  - People dynamic

Hard Skills vs. Soft Skills

- Hard Skills (Tangible)
  - Languages
  - Technologies
  - Platforms
  - Architecture
  - SDLC
- Soft Skills (Intangible)
  - Professional interaction
  - Leadership
  - Communication
  - Personal Habits
  - Friendliness
- Most jobs –> *both* are required

Honing Your Hard Skills



- Evaluate your options
  - Evaluate technology stacks, platforms, languages
  - C#, JS/TS, Java, Python, Kotlin, Go, Rust
  - Web, Mobile, Cloud, Data, AI, DevOps
- Hone a tech stack vs being a generalist
  - “Jack of all trades and the master of none”
    - Double-edged sword

Honing Your Soft Skills

- Skills gained from tenure and job experiences
- Learn from the wise and experienced
- Examine those that are successful (and deserve to be)
- Gravitate toward a mentor
- Monitor feedback
- Take a class
- Time and experience will help

Domain Knowledge

- Underrated skillset in our industry
- Can make exceptional engineers move through molasses
- Examples of domain knowledge
  - Financial
  - Government
  - Medical
  - Retail
  - Automotive
- Find a SME and latch on if possible
- Ramp-up aggressively early

Continual Education

- You will never, ever, ever need to stop learning new things
- You Can't Know It All (YCKIA), But Keep Pursuing After It Anyway
  - Fight Imposter Syndrome!
- Avenues to gain knowledge
  - Blogs
  - Videos
  - Whitepapers
  - Magazines
  - Conferences
  - OSS contributions
  - AI
- Be careful not to get too stagnant
  - You might find yourself being yesterday's news

Finding a Mentor

- This applies to *any* stage of one's career
- Gravitate toward experience
  - Knowledge transfer
  - Skill development
- Helpful to *navigate* company nuances
  - Networking opportunities
- Provide guidance on next steps
  - Career guidance
  - Feedback and critique
- Consider also *being* a mentor

Avoid Pitfalls

- Overcommitting
- Avoid drama and gossip
- Remain professional
- Resolve conflicts
- Golden Handcuffs
- Excessive movement between jobs

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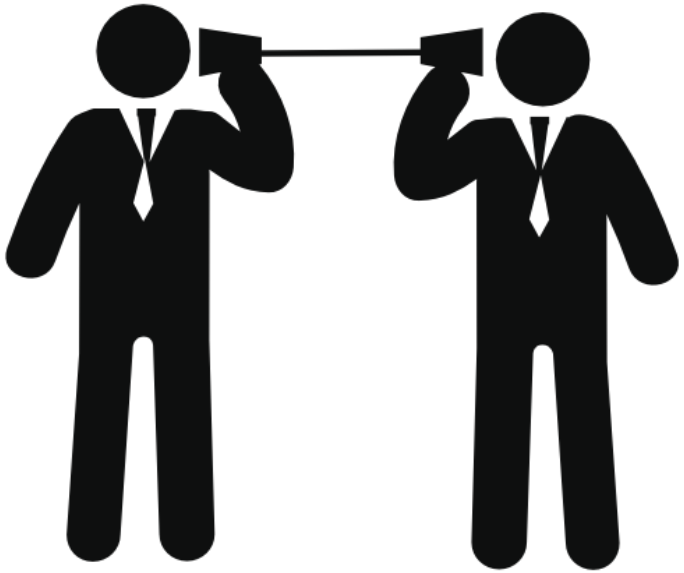
Communication and Transparency



- Clear communication
- Do well with the basics
- Be transparent
  - Issues
  - Concerns
  - Blockers
  - Goals
- No sweeping under the rug
- May determine successful outcomes vs unwanted surprises

Getting Feedback

- Constructive criticism can be hard
- Move the ego aside
- Look at the positive
- Leverage for growth
- Make course corrections
- Set improvement goals

Career Progression

- One generalization
  - 0-3 years: entry-level
  - 3-6 years: mid-level
  - 6-10 years: senior
  - 10-15 years: leadership
  - 15-20+ years: ?
- Pay Increases
  - Let's be honest: money does matter
- Strategic Job Moves
- Job Security
- Benchmark yourself against the wider community
  - *Not* just the place you currently are employed

Fork in the Road

- Is it a natural progression to go into management in our field?
  - Answer: no
  - A linear path would be increased skillset
- Great Software Engineers != Great Managers
  - Manager vs. *Leader*
- Leave the code behind!
  - Own your craft
  - Concentrate on leadership
- If you don't like working with others, stay away
- Caution: Leadership jobs narrow in availability

Networking is Key

- Making professional relationships
  - More important than ever
- Gold Key
  - Future endeavors
- Quality networking relationships
  - 2-way street
- Recruiters
  - Double edged sword
- Robust support system

That Next Career Move – Why?

- Stagnation
- Poor working environment
- Company Outlook
- Pay
- Responsibilities
- Falling Behind
- …or not moving at all
  - The grass isn’t always greener

That Next Career Move – How?

- Keep your resume warm
- Send Beacon to your Network
- Research
  - Job role
  - Benefits (PTO?)
  - Company DNA
- Interview
  - Technical vs Non-Technical
- Career Coach

Company and Role DNA

- Company Evaluation
  - Domain of interest
  - Fortune 500 vs. Startups
  - Public vs. Private
  - Company size
  - Geography
  - Remote
- Role Evaluation
  - Responsibility
  - Technology stack
  - Travel
  - Pay / benefits
  - Coworkers
  - Culture

Long Term Decisions

- Role and Responsibilities
- Live to work, or work to live?
- Getting paid to do what we love
- Enhancing the aspects one enjoys the most
- Where to settle?
  - …or settle at all
- Startup vs. Corporate America
- Contracting vs. Consulting vs. FTE

Do what makes you happy

- Find out what motivates you
  - Money
  - Title
  - Notoriety
  - Domain / Area
  - Company's work
  - Community Contributions
- The motivation may change over time
  - Reassess your situation annually
  - Make a change *if needed*
  - Enjoy what you do!

Thank you! Q&A

http://c1.staticflickr.com/1/28/65098350_b7bd96f38_b.jpg

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